he and his brothers diversified into real estate around Ujjain.

As CM, Yadav has sought to leave an imprint distinct from that of his predecessor, Chouhan. His government unveiled a new industrial policy, shifted from city-specific planning to developing metropolitan regions centred around Bhopal, Indore and Ujjain, and identified dairying as a priority sector to boost farm incomes. His government's ambitions, however, have been constrained by finances. With flagship welfare schemes such as Ladli Behna consuming over Rs 20,000 crore annually, besides the CM Kisan Samman Yojana, there has been little room for new capital-intensive programmes.

Officials who have worked closely with Yadav describe him as decisive. "The CM's core strength is his decision-making ability. If he is convinced about something, one can expect it to be cleared in the shortest possible time," says a principal secretary-rank IAS officer. He cites the long-pending issue of reservations in promotions—stuck for nearly a decade—as an example of Yadav pushing through a resolution once he had made up his mind.

That decisiveness, however, has not always translated into a smooth relationship with the bureaucracy. It is an open secret in Bhopal that Yadav and chief secretary Anurag Jain, an officer said to have impeccable credentials, do not see eye to eye on certain issues, especially bureaucratic postings. The CM's secretariat has also seen frequent changes at the top, though over time Yadav has built a trusted inner circle comprising additional chief secretaries Neeraj Mandloi and Rajesh Rajora, public relations commissioner Manish Singh and several officers posted in his hometown.

Even so, many BJP legislators believe that the bureaucracy has become increasingly assertive in the past few months, citing the recent 'transfer season' as a case in point. "If an MLA has a personal rapport with a departmental secretary or district collector, the chances of getting a recommendation accepted are much higher. Even if a minister approves a proposal and marks it to the department, there is no guarantee it will go through," says a first-time BJP MLA from the Mahakoshal region. He also cites the discontinuation of regular divisional review meetings involving senior bureaucrats as one reason decision-making has slowed in recent months. Some smaller initiatives—the PM Shri Air Ambulance Service and PM Shri Heli Paryatan Seva—have also faced operational disruptions.

POLITICAL TIGHTROPE

But governance is not the only thing testing Yadav's mettle, politics is proving to be equally challenging. To begin with, the CM inherited a government with multiple power centres. But the BJP's central leadership sought to ease the transition by limiting the old guard's representation in the cabinet. Even so, it is well known that Yadav's equations with senior colleagues such as Kailash Vijayvargiya, Prahlad Patel and Vijay Shah have not been smooth.



"CM MOHAN YADAV SHOULD EXPLAIN THE ALLEGATIONS IN THE MEDIA. WE DEMAND A PROBE HEADED BY A SERVING SUPREME COURT JUDGE"

JITU PATWARI
President, MP Congress

One of Yadav's most striking decisions has been to retain as many as 11 portfolios, while most senior ministers in his 30-member cabinet handle just one prominent department. Besides heading the government, Yadav holds Home, Industries, Mining, Forest, Public Relations and Narmada Valley Development, among others—an unprecedented concentration of authority in recent politics in Madhya Pradesh. Chouhan retained far fewer departments during his tenure, while Digvijaya Singh held virtually none in his final term. "Retaining such a large number of portfolios takes a toll on the functioning of departments," says a political observer in Bhopal. "But it has been done to keep the CM clearly above his cabinet colleagues."

At the same time, Yadav has cultivated his own political team. Ministers such as Rao Uday Pratap Singh, Rakesh Singh, Chetanya Kasyap and Narendra Patel are regarded as close to him, although speculation over a cabinet reshuffle continues. Whenever it comes, it is likely to provide another opportunity for the CM to stamp his authority on the government.

Yadav—regarded as a protégé of former Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) Sah Sarkaryavah, Suresh Soni—has also tried to balance governance with the RSS ideological priorities. His government has initiated the process for implementing the Uniform Civil Code, while the ban on liquor sales in 19 towns of religious significance was widely viewed as another pro-Sangh move, though it appears to have had little practical impact. Alcohol is available outside municipal limits, and there is no ban on drinking, only on its sale within the prescribed area. However, at the same time, sections of the Sangh privately express disappointment over the limited emphasis on expanding Sanskrit education.

Within the BJP organisation, Yadav now commands greater influence. The election of Betul MLA Khandelwal as state BJP president, the reconstitution of the state executive and the appointment of political heads to state corporations and boards have all been widely seen as reflecting the CM's growing clout. Recently, he also earned goodwill with the central leadership by helping the BJP secure a third Rajya Sabha seat from the state despite lacking the numbers on paper.

That political capital is now being tested. With the Uttar Pradesh assembly election due next year and resignations over media reports largely a thing of the past, Yadav appears focused on challenges closer home. An upcoming byelection in Datia will test the BJP's electoral machinery, while mending ties with senior colleagues will be crucial if he is to lead the party into the 2028 assembly election.

But, for now, Yadav must overcome the land row to regain the political narrative. ■